

Donna, Barbara Grizzuti Harrison and Caryl Phillips all lean forward uncomfortably, their chins or cheeks supported by a fist or hand. (Presumably their own hands, but who knows?) They all look like failed lounge acts appearing at your local piano bar. Mr. Updike appears ready to launch into an angst-laden version of "Sometimes When We Touch."

Tom Wicker, Thomas Powers and Saul Bellow, lest we miss the point that they are writers, or at least somehow associated with books, have all positioned themselves in front of bookshelves.

There's a nice stream rushing by Ann Druyan and her husband and co-author, Carl Sagan, on "Shadows of Forgotten Ancestors." Ms. Druyan looks sensitive. Mr. Sagan looks a bit queasy, no doubt longing for a bookcase or a place to rest his weary chin. Even the stylish and innovative dust jacket protecting "The Secret History" shows its author, Donna Tartt, standing in front of a whole gaggle of trees. (Or forest, if you want to get technical.)

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If there are any new clichés, it's simply the gender mixing of the old ones. Al Gore leans against a tree. He looks as sensitive as Ms. Druyan. "Earth in the Balance" is about ecology, so I guess you wouldn't want to see Mr. Gore grilling a spotted owl. Annie Dillard demonstrates her versatility on the covers of "Teaching a Stone to Talk" and "The Writing Life." On the first, she supports her left cheek in hand, and on the second her right cheek, while grasping a pen in the supporting hand. (Get it? A pen. "The Writing Life"?) On the jacket of "The English Patient" the novelist Michael Ondaatje adds a twofold twist: He leans forward, his (bear



Barbara Taylor Bradford



Jackie Collins



Judith Krantz

With Nature



Al Gore



Jeremy Bernstein

With Props

